I said: *They've split up and we're down to one bike.*

Permission to fire.

Dave said to use the Hellfire. I was nervous about using it, however; I shot the 30-mm cannon instead.

Mistake. I hit the motorbike. One man down, presumably dead, but one hopped off and ran into a building.

We circled, called in ground troops.

You were right, I told Dave. *Should've used the Hellfire*.

No worries, he said. *It was your first time*.

Long after returning to base, I did a sort of mental scan. I'd been in combat before, I'd killed before, but this was my most direct contact with the enemy—ever. Other engagements felt more impersonal. This one was eyes on target, finger on trigger, fire away.

I asked myself how I felt.

Traumatized?

No.

Sad?

No.

Surprised?

No. Prepared in every way. Doing my job. What we'd trained for.

I asked myself if I was callous, perhaps desensitized. I asked myself if my non-reaction was connected to a long-standing ambivalence towards death.

I didn't think so.

It was really just simple maths. These were bad people doing bad things to our guys. Doing bad things to the world. If this guy I'd just removed from the battlefield hadn't already killed British soldiers, he soon would. Taking him meant saving British lives, sparing British families. Taking him meant fewer young men and women wrapped like mummies and shipped home on hospital beds, like the lads on my plane four years earlier, or the wounded men and women I'd visited at Selly Oak and other hospitals, or the brave team with whom I'd marched to the North Pole.